

Referee Report

A Skeptical Review of Post-Industrial Localism, Version 1.0

Adversarial peer review · Prepared for Malcolm R. Smith, Savvy Security LLC

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Manuscript reviewed: *Post-Industrial Localism: A Political Theory for Decentralized Prosperity and Strategic State Capacity* (Version 1.0)

Reviewer field: Political theory / American political development / political economy

Recommendation: Revise and resubmit — major revisions. The core intuition is publishable; the current execution is not.

0. Summary judgment

This paper is trying to solve a real and underserved problem: how to get responsiveness and legitimacy from small-scale institutions *without* giving up the ability of a continental state to act decisively. Most contemporary frameworks pick one horn. The refusal to pick is the paper's genuine contribution, and it is the reason I am recommending revision rather than rejection.

But as written, the paper has four structural defects that a hostile reader will use to dismiss it in a paragraph:

1. **The diagnosis is probably wrong.** The paper blames “bureaucratic overload from centralized administration.” The best available evidence points at something close to the opposite pathology — fragmentation and proliferating veto points. If the diagnosis is wrong, the prescription makes the disease worse.
2. **Subsidiarity is invoked, not operationalized.** “Smallest competent authority” is not a decision rule until you specify what makes an authority competent. Without that, the framework can justify any assignment of any function to any level.
3. **There is no theory of local failure.** The paper treats scale as morally loaded — small is trustworthy, large is exhausted. Historically, the most durable engines of American domination have been local: exclusionary zoning, Jim Crow, machine politics, company towns.
4. **The Bitcoin plank contradicts Pillar III.** You cannot simultaneously demand a federal government with reserve capacity to stabilize the economy in a crisis and a fixed-supply money that government cannot expand in a crisis. This is not a tension to be managed. It is a contradiction, and a referee will kill the paper over it.

Everything below is in service of fixing these. I have tried to supply repairs, not just objections.

One housekeeping note before the substance: verify every citation in this report against the original source before you publish. I have been careful, but citation-checking is your responsibility as the author, and Section 6 will explain why that matters more than usual for this particular manuscript.

1. What actually works — keep this

Do not let the criticism below obscure the assets.

- **The refusal of the size axis.** Most decentralization arguments are covert shrink-the-state arguments. Yours is not, and you say so explicitly in Pillar III. That is a real position in logical space and almost nobody occupies it.
 - **The layered-responsibility architecture.** The instinct that different problems have different natural scales is correct and has serious empirical backing you have not yet claimed (see §7).
 - **The rootedness-plus-reach economic vision.** The observation that digital infrastructure lets people participate in global markets without leaving their communities is the most contemporary thing in the paper and deserves far more than the paragraph it gets.
 - **The reserve-capacity framing of federal power.** The metaphor is wrong (see §3) but the underlying intuition — that a state which is constantly firefighting cannot build — is defensible and can be re-grounded.
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2. Major objection I: the diagnosis is empirically unsupported

Your Introduction asserts that centralized administrative structures generate bureaucratic overload, slow response, and inefficiency, and that federal capacity is therefore “expended” on routine administration. The paper offers no evidence for this. The available evidence cuts against it.

The federal administrative state has not grown. The federal civilian workforce numbered roughly two million in the early 1960s and remains roughly two million today, while the U.S. population grew from about 180 million to about 340 million and federal spending grew by multiples. As a share of population, the federal workforce is a fraction of its 1960s size. Whatever is wrong with American governance, it is not that federal headcount has ballooned and crowded out crisis capacity. (Brookings, “Is government too big?”, 2025; DiIulio, *Bring Back the Bureaucrats*, 2014; Volcker Alliance, *The True Size of Government*.)

A live complication you must address. As of 2026 the federal civilian workforce stands at roughly its lowest level since the mid-1960s following large-scale reductions in 2025–26, with substantial substitution toward contractors. This is contested terrain and I take no position on the merits. But it is now impossible to publish a paper premised on federal administrative bloat without engaging the fact that the trend line is running hard the other way. A reader will notice. Address it directly or the paper will read as written before 2024.

The better-supported diagnosis is vetocracy. Fukuyama’s account of institutional decay locates the American pathology in the multiplication of veto points rather than in state size. Kagan’s *Adversarial Legalism* traces it to the substitution of litigation for administration. Bagley’s “The Procedure Fetish” argues that proceduralism intended to legitimate the state has instead paralyzed it. Dunkelman’s *Why Nothing Works* (2025) frames it as a long Jeffersonian turn within progressivism — a “cultural aversion to power” that inserted veto points throughout public decision-making, many of them wielded locally. Klein and Thompson’s *Abundance* (2025) makes the parallel case that the binding constraint is not money but the inability to build.

Why this is fatal if unaddressed. Dunkelman’s account is, in effect, a direct rebuttal of your framework. He observes that the same coalitions demanding strong central protection of individual rights also grant local communities veto power over housing, transmission, and infrastructure — and that this combination is why nothing gets built. Post-Industrial Localism, as currently specified, would systematically expand exactly that local veto.

The repair — and it is a good one. Distinguish two things the paper currently conflates:

Authority to act (initiate, deliver, adapt, experiment) — decentralize aggressively. **Authority to block** (veto, delay, litigate, condition) — centralize, or eliminate.

This single distinction converts your framework from a contributor to vetocracy into a *cure* for it. It also reconciles you with the abundance literature rather than putting you in its crosshairs. Make it the spine of the revised paper.

3. Major objection II: state capacity is not a reservoir

Pillar III rests on a conservation metaphor: resolve issues locally, and the federal government “retains surplus capacity.” This treats capacity as a fixed stock depleted by use.

That is not how state capacity works. Mann’s distinction between *despotic power* (power over society) and *infrastructural power* (the capacity to penetrate society and implement decisions) is the relevant frame, and infrastructural power is built through routine use: personnel, expertise, institutional memory, relationships with implementing partners, functioning data systems. An agency that does routine work well has capacity available for crises. An agency hollowed out in quiet years cannot surge in loud ones. Rebuilding an atrophied capability under emergency conditions is precisely when it is most expensive and most likely to fail.

Mettler’s work on the G.I. Bill sharpens the point in a way that should worry you: federal programs did not crowd out civic participation, they *manufactured* it. Beneficiaries became more civically engaged, not less. Her later work on the “submerged state” adds the corollary — federal action that is invisible to citizens fails to generate the civic returns that visible action does.

The implication for your framework is significant and, handled well, is an upgrade: **civil society and state capacity are complements, not substitutes**. The zero-sum framing in Section 4 of your paper is not merely unsupported; it inverts the historical relationship.

Repair: rewrite Pillar III around *tempo* and *decision rights* rather than *volume*. The federal government should not be preserved by *doing less*. It should be made capable by doing its own work well, in-house, with competent and well-paid staff, while being stripped of the authority to micromanage things it should not be deciding. “Federal capacity is built by exercise, not conserved by disuse” is the sentence you want.

4. Major objection III: subsidiarity without an assignment rule is not a theory

Your Doctrine of Subsidiarity states that authority should sit at “the most local level capable of addressing a problem effectively.” This is a tautology dressed as a principle. Everything depends on “capable,” and the paper never defines it. As written, the doctrine can justify local control of monetary policy or federal control of library hours, because “capable” is unconstrained.

The literature has done this work and you should claim it:

- **Oates’s Decentralization Theorem** (*Fiscal Federalism*, 1972; JEL 1999): decentralized provision dominates when preferences vary across jurisdictions and there are no spillovers or scale economies; centralization dominates when spillovers or scale economies are large.
- **Hayek, “The Use of Knowledge in Society”** (1945): the epistemic case — dispersed, local, time-and-place knowledge that cannot be aggregated centrally. This is a much stronger foundation for you than the Hayek monetary material you currently use.
- **Peterson’s City Limits** (1981): local governments can pursue developmental and allocational policy but cannot sustain redistributive policy, because mobile capital and mobile people exit. This is the constraint your Pillar I ignores entirely.
- **Treisman, *The Architecture of Government*** (2007): a systematically skeptical review finding that the general claims made for decentralization mostly do not survive contact with evidence — outcomes are conditional on specific institutional details.
- **Bardhan, “Decentralization of Governance and Development”** (JEP 2002) and the elite-capture literature: decentralization transfers power to whoever is locally dominant, which is not always, or usually, the median citizen.
- **Rodden, *Hamilton’s Paradox*** (2006): the soft-budget-constraint problem. Subnational units that expect bailouts overspend and export risk upward.

Repair: replace the doctrine with an explicit, four-test assignment protocol (spillover, scale, information, fiscal capacity), plus a stated burden of proof and explicit non-derogation clauses. I have drafted one in the companion paper; use it or write your own, but the vague version cannot survive review.

5. Major objection IV: no theory of local tyranny

This is the objection I would lead with if I were reviewing for a top-five journal.

The paper assumes local institutions are benign. It contains no account of what happens when a community’s routine functioning is the injustice. This is not a hypothetical failure mode; it is the central fact of American local government history.

- **Madison, *Federalist 10*** argues the *opposite* of your premise. Factional capture is more likely in small republics, not less; the extended republic dilutes faction. Your paper cites the American founding tradition without engaging its most famous argument about scale, and a reviewer will notice.
- **Tocqueville himself** — whom you cite twice — devotes major sections of *Democracy in America* to the tyranny of the majority and to the suffocating social conformity of small communities. You have taken half of Tocqueville.
- **Riker, *Federalism*** (1964): federalism’s practical American function for a century was the protection of local racial domination.
- **Rothstein, *The Color of Law*** (2017) and **Trounstein, *Segregation by Design*** (2018): segregation was not a market outcome or a federal imposition. It was produced by local governments using zoning, annexation, and service

provision — precisely the tools your framework devolves.

- **Purcell, “Urban Democracy and the Local Trap”** (*Urban Studies*, 2006): names the error directly. Scales have no inherent political character; localization can produce any outcome. Assuming the local is more democratic is a category mistake, and you make it.

Repair: the framework needs a normative backbone that can criticize domination *wherever* it originates — federal, market, or communal. Pettit’s republican theory of freedom as non-domination (*Republicanism*, 1997) is built for exactly this and is fully continuous with the classical republicanism you already claim. It gives you a principled reason to decentralize (concentrated central power dominates) *and* a principled reason to maintain strong federal guarantees (local majorities dominate too). Adopt it as a fifth doctrine and much of this objection dissolves.

6. Major objection V: the Bitcoin plank

This section will get the paper rejected in its current form. I want to be precise about why, because the underlying instinct is not crazy — the execution is.

6.1 It contradicts Pillar III

Pillar III promises a federal government with reserve capacity for “economic stabilization” and “economic disruptions.” A fixed-supply monetary standard the state cannot expand removes the primary instrument of macroeconomic stabilization. This is not a tension. It is a contradiction between two adjacent sections of the same paper.

The historical evidence is about as settled as macroeconomics gets. Eichengreen’s *Golden Fetters* (1992) and Bernanke and James (1991) establish that during the Great Depression the countries that abandoned the gold standard earliest recovered earliest, and those that clung to it longest suffered most. A hard-money standard converts a demand shock into a debt-deflation spiral precisely when your Pillar III promises decisive federal response.

6.2 The empirical record is now in

When you wrote this, the sovereign Bitcoin experiment was ongoing. It has concluded.

El Salvador adopted Bitcoin as legal tender in September 2021. The IMF’s assessment found that despite substantial public subsidy of transaction costs, acceptance and use by individuals and firms remained minimal, with no evidence of beneficial use for the unbanked, and identified the two binding constraints as extreme price volatility and the absence of an authority able to intervene against illiquidity, abuse, or fraud. Business surveys found the overwhelming majority of firms had never completed a single Bitcoin sale. In January 2025 the legislative assembly revoked legal tender status as a condition of a \$1.4 billion IMF Extended Fund Facility; taxes must be paid in dollars and acceptance is now voluntary.

You must engage this. A referee who knows the file and sees it unmentioned will conclude you are not arguing in good faith.

6.3 “Politically neutral money” is a category error

Every monetary rule distributes. A fixed-supply rule is not neutral between creditors and debtors; it systematically favors creditors and existing holders. This is a *political choice*, and it happens to be a choice against the constituency your Pillar II is written to serve — young families, apprentices, and small entrepreneurs, who are net debtors. Deflationary money raises the real burden of their obligations. Your monetary doctrine is at war with your economic doctrine.

The distributional problem compounds. Fixed supply plus highly concentrated initial holdings produces wealth concentration, which corrodes the rough civic equality that Pillar I’s whole account of community trust depends on.

6.4 The Hayek citation does not support what you use it for

Two problems. First, the quotation as given does not appear to be verbatim Hayek and I could not locate it in *Denationalisation of Money*; treat it as unsourced until you find the page. Second and more importantly, Hayek’s actual argument is for *competition among issuers* — a market process in which private currencies compete and the best-managed wins. That is close to the opposite of designating one fixed-supply asset as the standard by policy. You are citing Hayek in support of a monetary monopoly he was arguing against.

6.5 The steelman, which you should engage and then answer

To be fair to the position: Selgin's work on productivity-norm deflation argues that not all deflation is harmful, and Ammous's *The Bitcoin Standard* (2018) makes the coherent version of the case you are gesturing at. Cite them. Answering a serious opponent is stronger than ignoring one.

6.6 Repair

Split the plank into the defensible part and the indefensible part.

Keep: monetary and payments *pluralism*. The right to transact without permission. Protection against arbitrary debanking. Open payment rails and interoperability requirements. Skepticism of surveillance-capable retail CBDC design. Legal clarity for self-custody. This is a real, coherent, distinctively localist policy agenda and nobody else is articulating it well.

Drop: Bitcoin as the monetary *standard*.

Add: the thing you actually wanted, which is *rules-based macroeconomic policy* — a nominal anchor with a transparent rule, escape clauses for genuine emergencies, and fiscal rules with counterparts. This gets you politically-insulated money without disarming the state you spent Pillar III arguing for.

This is the single highest-value revision in the paper.

7. Major objection VI: the guild plank is contradicted by the economic history

Pillar II romanticizes guilds. The scholarship does not.

Ogilvie's *The European Guilds: An Economic Analysis* (Princeton, 2019) is the current standard treatment, built on two public datasets comprising thousands of quantitative and qualitative observations across Europe. Her findings run directly against your framing: guilds erected entry barriers, manipulated markets through price-setting and supply control, obstructed innovation, and systematically excluded women, migrants, Jews, and other outsiders. Where quality regulation existed it functioned largely to exclude non-guild producers. Her verdict is that guilds persisted not because they corrected market failures but because they benefited two groups — guild members and political elites.

Be fair to the other side: Epstein (*JEH*, 1998) argued that guilds solved real apprenticeship and human-capital problems, and the debate is not unanimous. But Ogilvie's evidentiary base is now the one to beat, and you cannot simply invoke guilds as an unexamined good.

The modern instance is worse, because it is live. Occupational licensing is the guild system's contemporary descendant. Roughly a quarter to nearly 30 percent of U.S. workers hold a government license, up from around five percent in the 1950s. Licensing raises incumbent wages on the order of 10–15 percent, reduces cross-occupational mobility, and reduces interstate migration; recent work finds increases in restrictions raise wages modestly while reducing employment more sharply, with restrictions concentrated in lower-wage occupations. A "guild economy" that does not distinguish itself sharply from this will simply reinvent it.

Repair — and this one substantially improves the paper. Draw a hard line:

Certification (voluntary, portable, competing certifiers, signals competence) — expand. **Licensure** (mandatory, jurisdiction-locked, controls entry) — narrow to genuine safety cases and make it reciprocal across states.

Reframed this way, Pillar II becomes a serious pro-mobility, pro-entry, pro-apprenticeship agenda rather than a nostalgia exercise. Cite Ogilvie *against* the naive version and you look like a scholar rather than an enthusiast.

8. Major objection VII: the housing question, which the paper must not dodge

This is the hardest bullet in the framework and there is no way around biting it.

Local control of land use is the single most consequential form of localism in America, and it is the one with the clearest empirical costs. Fischel's homevoter hypothesis explains the mechanism: local government is dominated by homeowners whose principal asset is their house, giving them a structural incentive to restrict supply. The aggregate consequences

are large. Glaeser and Gyourko (*JEP*, 2018) estimate meaningful annual GDP losses from excessive land-use restriction. Hsieh and Moretti (*AEJ: Macro*, 2019) estimate far larger effects.

Handle Hsieh-Moretti carefully. Their headline figure has been challenged — Greaney’s replication identified errors that the authors have acknowledged. Cite the paper, cite the correction, and lean on the more conservative Glaeser-Gyourko range. Doing this visibly will mark you as a careful author and will inoculate you against the reviewer who knows the file.

The uncomfortable conclusion stands regardless of which estimate you use: on the highest-stakes margin, *more localism makes Americans poorer and less mobile*. Hsieh and Moretti’s own framing is the one to quote in spirit — incumbent homeowners in high-productivity cities have a private incentive to restrict supply, and the costs land on everyone else in the country.

Repair: state the exception explicitly and defend it on your own principles. Land use fails your spillover test — a town’s refusal to build imposes costs on non-residents who have no vote there. Under your own subsidiarity protocol, correctly specified, housing *supply floors* belong at the state level. Local discretion over *form* (design, character, phasing) survives; local discretion over *quantity* does not.

A theory that bites this bullet in public is far more credible than one that quietly avoids it.

9. Major objection VIII: the framework punishes people for their zip code

If communities handle social needs first, then the quality of a citizen’s floor depends on the civic and fiscal wealth of the place they happen to live. Chetty and coauthors have documented enormous place-based variation in intergenerational mobility. Peterson’s constraint (§4) means poorer jurisdictions cannot tax their way out of it, because both capital and residents exit.

The paper has no answer to a child born in a county with a thin tax base and few institutions. As written, the framework tells that child that subsidiarity has spoken.

Repair — and this is where the paper can genuinely become distinctive. Separate financing from delivery:

Financing: national, progressive, equalizing. Rights and floors do not vary by county. **Delivery:** local, discretionary, experimental, accountable.

This is not a compromise with the theory. It is the theory, correctly specified — and it is empirically vindicated. Denmark is the most decentralized unitary country in the OECD as measured by spending: subnational government accounts for roughly 61 percent of public expenditure and about 33 percent of GDP, against OECD averages near 37 percent and 17 percent. It combines that with high national taxation, strong central state capacity, and high institutional trust. Germany’s *Finanzausgleich* and Canada’s equalization transfers embody the same principle.

You have been arguing for something that exists and works. You just had the financing architecture backwards. Claim the case.

10. Major objection IX: civic virtue is asserted, not produced

The Civic Virtue Doctrine states that citizens “are expected to participate.” Expected by whom, and what happens when they don’t? Putnam documented the decline; the causes he identifies — generational replacement, television, sprawl, changing household structure — are largely not responsive to exhortation.

The literature you are missing is the most useful thing in this report. Skocpol’s *Diminished Democracy* (2003) shows that American civic vitality historically ran through *federated* mass-membership associations — the Legion, the PTA, the Elks, the Masons, unions — organizations with local chapters nested inside state and national structures. They crossed class lines, trained ordinary people in democratic skill, and could move national policy. Their replacement by professionally staffed, memberless advocacy organizations, funded by foundations and direct mail rather than dues, is what hollowed out American civic life.

The implication reframes your entire Pillar I: **the operative variable was never “local.” It was “federated.”** Purely local associations do not aggregate; they cannot connect a town to a nation. What worked was the nesting structure — the local chapter that was also a rung on a national ladder.

This is a gift. It gives Pillar I an empirically grounded institutional design target instead of a moral exhortation, and it explains *why* the layered architecture in your Section 3 is right, which the paper currently only asserts.

11. Major objection X: the paper is unfalsifiable

There is not a single claim in the manuscript that could be shown to be wrong. No predictions, no indicators, no failure conditions, no implementation sequence. In its present form the framework is a worldview, not a theory.

Repair: add three sections that most ideological papers omit and that will distinguish yours immediately.

1. **Testable propositions** — what should we observe if this is right?
2. **Failure modes and safeguards** — what goes wrong, how would we know, what stops it?
3. **Objections and replies** — the strongest cases against, answered.

Papers that name their own failure conditions are read as serious. Papers that don't are read as advocacy.

12. Craft and scholarly-apparatus problems

12.1 The epigraphs are a liability. This needs blunt statement.

- *Tocqueville: “The health of a democratic society may be measured by the quality of functions performed by private citizens.”* I could not locate this in *Democracy in America* or in any scholarly edition. It appears only in quotation-aggregator sites, always without page citation, and it circulates in the same collections as the notorious “America is great because she is good” passage — which is a documented fabrication, traceable to a 1941 book and popularized by Eisenhower's and Clinton's speechwriters, and which Tocqueville never wrote. Until you can supply a volume, part, and chapter, cut it. Tocqueville wrote plenty you can actually cite; use the real material on associations in Volume II.
- *Aquinas: “The common good of the city is more divine than the good of one.”* The underlying line is Aristotle's (*Nicomachean Ethics* I.2), which Aquinas *quotes* — in the *Summa* he attributes it to “the Philosopher,” rendered in the standard English as the good of the nation being more godlike than the good of one man. Attributing it flatly to Aquinas's *Summa Theologica* is at minimum incomplete. Cite it properly or drop it.
- *Hayek on currency competition* — see §6.4. Unsourced as given.
- *Aristotle, “Man is by nature a political animal”* — this one is correct (*Politics* I.2, 1253a). It is also the only one of the four I can verify.

Three of four epigraphs are unsourced, misattributed, or apocryphal. For a paper whose authority rests on the Western political tradition, this is the kind of thing a reviewer treats as diagnostic. Fix it first; it is the cheapest large gain available.

12.2 The bibliography is four primary sources and zero contemporary scholarship. A political theory paper published today needs to show it knows what the last fifty years of political science, economics, and law have found. Right now it reads as though the literature stopped in 1274 with one detour to 1976.

12.3 “Post-Industrial” is undefined. Bell's *The Coming of Post-Industrial Society* (1973) gave the term a specific meaning: the shift to services, information, and theoretical knowledge as the axis of the economy. Either claim Bell's sense explicitly and use it, or choose a different adjective. As it stands it functions as atmosphere.

12.4 No engagement with rival frameworks. A new ideology must situate itself. The obvious neighbors: national conservatism; Deneen's postliberalism; Sandel's and Etzioni's communitarianisms; Catholic social teaching proper (*Rerum Novarum* 1891; *Quadragesimo Anno* 1931 §79, the locus classicus of subsidiarity); Bookchin's libertarian municipalism on the left; distributism; and abundance liberalism, which is your most direct contemporary competitor. Show what you offer that each does not.

12.5 The religious-institutions plank needs a First Amendment paragraph. Pillar I assigns social provision partly to religious organizations without addressing establishment questions, the charitable-choice record, or what happens to citizens in communities where the dominant religious institution will not serve them.

12.6 Missing ancestors you should be claiming. Ostrom is the most important omission and is discussed in §13. Also: Althusius; Nisbet's *The Quest for Community* (1953); Röpke; Jane Jacobs; Schumacher; Scott's *Seeing Like a State* (1998), whose account of *metis* is the best available epistemic defense of local knowledge; Levin's *A Time to Build* (2020).

13. The literature that would make this paper strong

If you read nothing else from this report, read this section.

Elinor and Vincent Ostrom are the intellectual foundation this paper has been missing. Ostrom, Tiebout, and Warren's 1961 *APSR* article introduced *polycentricity* — governance with multiple overlapping centers of decision-making, each with some autonomy, nested across levels. Elinor Ostrom's empirical program then tested it. The metropolitan policing studies of the 1970s found that areas served by a mix of large and small producers could capture scale economies where they existed while avoiding diseconomies where they did not, outperforming consolidated systems on efficiency and responsiveness. *Governing the Commons* (1990) supplied design principles for self-governance, including nested enterprises. The 2009 Nobel followed.

Why this matters to you specifically:

1. It is the *empirically validated* version of what you are arguing. You are currently making a normative argument that a Nobel laureate spent forty years demonstrating with field data.
2. It gives you overlapping and cross-cutting units, not just a clean four-level ladder. Real polycentric systems include special-purpose districts and functional authorities that cut across geography — a richer architecture than your Family → Community → State → Federal chain.
3. It removes the "small is good" naiveté. Ostrom's finding is not that small units are better; it is that *mixed* systems with both large and small producers outperform monocentric ones on some functions and not others.
4. It gives you a research program rather than a manifesto.

Rebuild the theoretical foundation on Ostrom. Keep Aristotle and Tocqueville as lineage; make Ostrom the load-bearing wall.

14. What the revised paper needs to contain

1. A corrected diagnosis: vetocracy and fragmentation, not size.
 2. The act/block distinction as the organizing principle.
 3. A four-test subsidiarity assignment protocol with non-derogation clauses.
 4. Pillar I rebuilt on *federation* (Skocpol), not proximity.
 5. Pillar II rebuilt on portable certification and open entry (Ogilvie), with the housing bullet bitten explicitly.
 6. Pillar III rebuilt on infrastructural power built by exercise (Mann, Mettler).
 7. Pillar IV replacing the Bitcoin standard with monetary pluralism plus rules-based stabilization.
 8. Non-domination (Pettit) as the normative backbone that lets you criticize local tyranny.
 9. National financing, local delivery — with Denmark, Germany, and Canada as evidence.
 10. Testable propositions, failure modes, and objections-and-replies.
 11. A real bibliography.
 12. Verified epigraphs, or none.
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15. Closing note to the author

The reason this report is long is that the paper is worth the effort. The position you are staking out — decentralize without disarming — is genuinely underoccupied, and the two literatures that would ground it (Ostrom on polycentricity, Skocpol on federation) are sitting unclaimed. What the manuscript currently lacks is not insight. It lacks adversarial pressure: the discipline of writing every paragraph as though the smartest person who disagrees with you is reading it.

Two of the repairs above will feel like concessions and are not. Biting the housing bullet and separating financing from delivery both look, on first pass, like retreats from localism. They are the opposite: they are what makes localism defensible to someone who does not already share your priors. A framework that can only be believed by people already inclined to believe it is a faction, not a theory.

The Bitcoin plank is the one place I would not negotiate. Everything else in the paper can be argued. That plank contradicts your own Pillar III, and any competent reviewer will find it in the first reading.

The companion document contains a full reconstruction implementing these repairs. Treat it as a draft to argue with, not a replacement — the ideas should stay yours, and you will defend them better if you have fought with the revisions rather than accepted them.